

Bolt: Where Everyday Life Connects

From how we move through the city to how we order dinner or manage company expenses – digital platforms are quietly reshaping everyday life in the country. Bolt Azerbaijan, operating across ride-hailing, food delivery, and corporate mobility, sits at the centre of this transformation.

In the following conversations, the General Managers of Bolt Food, Bolt Ride – Hailing, and Bolt for Business reflect on how technology is adapting to a market that still values human connection, how habits are evolving, and what the future of seamless, integrated services might look like.

INTERVIEW FATIMA ABBASOVA PHOTO GUNEL IBRAHIMOVA, PRESS MATERIALS

Dilara Tomtiyeva, General Manager of Bolt Food

How does the Azerbaijani market differ from other countries where Bolt Food operates?

In Azerbaijan, food is deeply personal. It's central to celebrations, friendships, and even business, often bringing people together around the table. Going to the bazaar and carefully choosing the best fruits, vegetables, or meat is a family ritual in itself. Compared to many Western European markets, where digital trust is more established, Azerbaijan still places strong value on the human element. When something goes wrong, people want to speak to a real person and feel heard. Word of mouth is also extremely powerful – a recommendation from family or friends often matters more than any campaign. However, the market is changing quickly. The younger generation is increasingly comfortable with digital experiences, which aligns well with what we offer.

What digital solutions do you use to make the customer experience more convenient?

Convenience is about removing friction at every step. We use machine learning to predict preparation and delivery times as accurately as possible. We also look at trends – where and when customers order, and the context behind it – so we can serve them better in the moment. Our biggest recent milestone is the launch of Bolt Plus in Azerbaijan this month. This subscription brings our ride and food services under one umbrella, offering free delivery, additional discounts, and cashback. What really matters is that these benefits work across both platforms, so whether you save time on a ride or earn a discount on food, it all becomes part of one seamless experience.

How do you engage with local restaurants, especially those for which the digital environment is still something new?

Onboarding a restaurant partner isn't just a technical process; it's a relationship. We have video materials to help them understand how to work with our tablets and the partner portal, as well as agents to guide them through every step. However, for some partners, nothing replaces face-to-face interaction, so we do our best to offer that

personal, offline support whenever possible.

We've noticed that the more a restaurant engages with the portal – managing its menu, tracking performance, and responding to feedback – the better its results. And that makes sense: no one understands a business better than the people behind it do. We don't want to tell them how to run their restaurant; we want to give them the best tools so they can make smarter decisions and grow.

In your opinion, has food delivery in Baku become part of everyday life, or is it still seen mainly as a convenient, secondary service?

It's becoming a genuine part of life, and I will make it personal because I think it illustrates the point better than any statistic. As a working mum, food delivery isn't a luxury for me; it's about time – the time I get to spend with my children instead of running to the store for a last-minute ingredient or standing in a queue. The pandemic sped things up, but what keeps it going is a deeper shift in how people value their time and energy. I think most of us have had that moment of almost giving up – then opening the app and having it quietly solve the problem. With Bolt Plus, we're making that experience even smoother. The goal is to become a consistent, rewarding part of your day – not just a backup plan.



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# Create innovations that customers love - not what's  
easy for us.  
build(feature) if feature.is_loved_by_customers() else  
skip(feature)
```

Customers First
Create innovations that customers
love — not what's easy for us.

Bolt

Get it Done

Get it Done
Take ownership, act with
deliver results — not excuses

Bolt

Standard

Set the Standard
Build diverse, high performance teams whose
work sets the bar others seek to reach.

In Azerbaijan,
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Trust is the foundation of everything we do “



Ilkin Zeynalli, General Manager of Bolt Ride – Hailing

You are new to this role and bring substantial experience from the FMCG and technology sectors. How would you describe your experience at Bolt so far, and what opportunities are you discovering?

Joining Bolt after Procter & Gamble and Samsung Electronics has been a clear shift in pace and impact. Decisions and market feedback happen almost in real time, making the role highly dynamic and accountable.

There's also strong continuity with my past experience – structured thinking, consumer focus, and execution still matter, but here they need to be simplified and applied much faster.

Having worked across seven markets in Türkiye, the Caucasus, and Central Asia has shaped my approach. It reinforced the importance of local nuances, adaptability, and leading diverse teams, which is critical in a business like Bolt.

What excites me most is the level of ownership and the immediate impact you can drive. The key opportunities I see are improving marketplace efficiency, becoming sharper in understanding local market dynamics, and building a highly aligned, fast-moving team.

Security and transparency are the key expectations of users today. How does Bolt address them from a technological perspective?

Trust is the foundation of everything we do, and transparency is built into every step of the experience on our platform. Before a passenger even enters the car, they can see the driver's name, photo, and vehicle details. All drivers go through a vetting process, and those who don't meet our safety and service standards are removed from the platform. We also give users direct control through in-app features. The Pickup Code ensures the correct match between passenger and driver, Trip Sharing lets users share their live journey with a trusted contact, and the Safety Button provides instant access to support if needed.

In addition, we maintain a continuous feedback loop where both passengers and drivers can report suspicious or inappropriate behaviour directly in the app. This shared responsibility helps keep the platform safe and transparent.

What technologies form the foundation of effective trip management in a city with traffic as busy as Baku's?

Baku is a city of contrasts, with rapid population growth and an urban layout that makes demand highly unpredictable. In such an environment, mobility management requires intelligent technology, not just a large fleet. At the core of our system is real-time data. Our algorithms constantly analyse traffic, demand across districts, and

driver availability to match passengers with drivers as efficiently as possible. Routes also adjust dynamically, so drivers respond to real conditions rather than fixed paths.

With tens of thousands of active partners in Azerbaijan and over a million active monthly users, we process a significant amount of data, which works in our favour: the more trips on the platform, the more accurate our demand predictions become.

How has Bolt Ride – Hailing changed the everyday reality of drivers?

I feel strongly about it, particularly as the new General Manager of Bolt Ride – Hailing, because the impact on drivers is often overlooked. Before platforms like Bolt, a driver's income was largely unpredictable – depending on location, timing, luck, and informal networks. Today, drivers on our platform have access to real-time demand, can choose when and where they work, and see exactly what they earn per trip with full transparency. That shift from uncertainty to clarity is genuinely life-changing for many.

But it's not only about income; it's also about dignity and professional identity. Our drivers aren't just transporting people from A to B – they're effectively running their own micro-businesses, supported by tools, data, and a broader community. Through regular training and communication on road safety and professional conduct, we help them feel part of a structured, professional system.



Salman Babazade Jr., General Manager of Bolt for Business

Moving from the public sector to Bolt is quite a significant career shift.

What has been the most surprising for you in this new environment?

The most surprising aspect has been the speed of execution and decision-making.

In the public sector, decisions are naturally more structured and long-term, with multiple layers of alignment. At Bolt, I experienced a shift towards a highly agile environment, where ideas can move from concept to implementation very quickly.

What stood out to me is that this speed is not chaotic, it is actually data-driven and outcome-focused. Teams are empowered to take ownership, test ideas, and iterate based on real market feedback. Another surprising element has been the level of ownership at every level of the organisation. People are not just executing tasks; they are thinking like business owners, constantly asking how to improve efficiency, customer experience, and results.

Coming from the public sector, this required an adjustment, but it also unlocked a new level of impact. It allowed me to combine my structured background with a more dynamic, performance-oriented approach, which I believe is a powerful combination for driving growth in a market like Azerbaijan.

How ready are Azerbaijani companies for the digitalisation of their transport and logistics processes?

Azerbaijani companies are somewhere in the middle of this transition. Larger enterprises tend to rely on digital tools to track costs, manage operations, and keep everything transparent and accountable. In contrast, many small and medium-sized businesses still operate more traditionally, using manual processes, cash payments, or informal transport arrangements.

However, the overall direction is clearly shifting toward greater transparency and wider use of cashless. Notably, this shift isn't just about adopting new technology, but also about changing how companies think and operate.

What is the key difference between Bolt for Business and traditional corporate transport solutions?

The main difference comes down to flexibility and control at scale. Traditional corporate transport solutions are usually quite rigid – they rely on fixed contracts, offer limited fleet options, and often lack real transparency regarding usage and costs.

Bolt for Business takes a different approach, offering companies on-demand, scalable mobility with real-time tracking and detailed reporting. They can also set clear policies, deciding who can use the

service, when, where, and within what budget.

As a result, transport is no longer treated as a fixed expense; instead, it becomes something dynamic that companies can monitor, adjust, and optimise as their needs change.

Could we imagine a future in which using Bolt for Business for corporate trips becomes as easy and commonplace as ordering a taxi in everyday life?

Absolutely, and in many ways, we're already heading there. As one of the winners of the fourth "Yüksəliş" competition, I've seen how important it is for businesses to embrace innovation. The goal is to make corporate mobility feel effortless with no manual approvals or reimbursement paperwork. For employees, it should be as simple as booking a ride without a second thought. For companies, everything remains structured and controlled in the background.

Looking ahead, it's easy to imagine a workplace where booking a business ride feels as routine as sending an email. At the same time, companies will rely more on automated policies and integrated systems to manage everything efficiently.

And it won't stop at transport. We're moving toward a broader ecosystem that could include rides, food delivery, and logistics – all connected on a single platform.



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